1. SOAR Fundamentals

1. What does SOAR stand for?

SOAR stands for Security Orchestration, Automation and Response. It helps security teams coordinate tools, automate repetitive tasks, and respond to security incidents.

2. What is the difference between orchestration and automation?

- Orchestration: Connects and coordinates different security tools and processes.
- Automation: Executes tasks automatically without requiring manual intervention for every step.

Example: orchestration connects a SIEM, VirusTotal, and a firewall; automation checks an IP reputation and sends a notification.

3. How does a SOAR platform differ from a SIEM and an EDR?

- SIEM: Collects and analyzes logs to detect suspicious activity and generate alerts.
- EDR: Monitors and protects endpoints such as computers and servers.
- SOAR: Coordinates security tools and automates incident response workflows.

4. What problem does SOAR solve in a security operations center (SOC)?

SOAR reduces repetitive manual work, speeds up incident response, standardizes procedures, and helps analysts manage large numbers of security alerts.

2. Playbooks and Response

5. What is a playbook in the context of SOAR?

A playbook is a predefined sequence of steps that automates or guides the investigation and response to a security event.

6. What information does a playbook define?

A playbook defines:

- Trigger: what starts the workflow.
- Goal: the desired outcome.
- Data: information available to the workflow.
- Steps: actions performed in order.

- Decision points: conditions and branches.
- Escalation: when a human analyst is needed.
- Failure handling: what happens when a step fails.

7. What is the difference between a playbook and a runbook?

- Playbook: A workflow that can be executed automatically or guide a response.
- Runbook: A documented set of instructions, often followed manually by an analyst.

8. Give an example of a security alert that could be handled by a playbook.

A phishing email alert. The playbook extracts URLs, checks their reputation, creates a ticket, and notifies the analyst. If a malicious URL is confirmed, it can request approval before blocking it.

3. Shuffle

9. What is Shuffle and what is it designed for?

Shuffle is a security-focused SOAR platform designed to build workflows that connect security tools and automate incident response.

10. What are the basic building blocks of a Shuffle workflow?

- Triggers
- Nodes and integrations
- Variables and data
- Logic and conditions
- Actions and workflow branches

11. What is a trigger and what is a node?

- Trigger: Starts a workflow when an event occurs, such as receiving an alert.
- Node: Performs a task within the workflow, such as checking an IP, creating a ticket, or sending a notification.

12. How does Shuffle integrate with other security tools?

Shuffle uses integrations, applications, APIs, and webhooks to exchange data and execute actions across security tools.

4. n8n

13. What is n8n and how does it differ from Shuffle?

n8n is a general-purpose workflow automation platform that connects applications and APIs. Shuffle focuses specifically on security operations, while n8n can automate many types of tasks, including cybersecurity workflows.

14. What are the core concepts in an n8n workflow?

- Workflow: The complete automation.
- Trigger node: Starts the workflow.
- Regular nodes: Process data or perform actions.
- Credentials: Securely store authentication information.
- Expressions and variables: Access and use data between nodes.
- Logic nodes: Apply conditions and direct the workflow into different branches.

15. Give examples of security automation tasks n8n can perform.

- Check suspicious IP addresses using a threat-intelligence API.
- Receive security alerts through a webhook.
- Send notifications when an alert has high severity.
- Create incident tickets.
- Collect and enrich security information.

16. Why is self-hosting important for these automation platforms?

Self-hosting allows an organization to run the platform on its own infrastructure, giving it more control over data, network access, privacy, and configuration. However, the organization must manage updates, security, backups, and availability.

5. Responsible Automation

17. Why should high-risk actions remain semi-automated?

Actions such as blocking critical systems, quarantining devices, or deleting files can cause serious damage if performed incorrectly. Human approval helps prevent false positives and unintended consequences.

18. Why is it important to log and audit automated actions?

Logging records what happened, when it happened, and what actions were performed. Auditing allows analysts to review decisions, investigate incidents, troubleshoot failures, and maintain accountability.

19. How should credentials used by automation platforms be protected?

Credentials should be stored in a secure credential vault or secrets manager, access should follow the principle of least privilege, and keys should be rotated regularly. Never hardcode API keys or passwords in workflow code.

20. Why is documentation and maintenance important for playbooks?

Documentation explains how a playbook works and who is responsible for it. Maintenance keeps it compatible with changing tools, APIs, infrastructure, and security requirements.